FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

For a robust democracy, a strong Opposition is as necessary as for the ruling party to have a stable majority. The Narendra Modi-led BJP juggernaut seemed unstoppable in the run-up to the general election in May 2024. But in mid-2023, the Opposition got its act together and formed a seemingly formidable alliance of 27 like-minded parties. Better known by its handy acronym 'I.N.D.I.A.' than by its full form, 'Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance', it promised to pose a substantial challenge to the BJP. But considering the latest developments from the camp, they are not even inclusive amongst themselves. I.N.D.I.A. seems to have flattered to deceive. Mamata Banerjee was already emitting unfriendly noises in West Bengal, refusing to make a family meal out of the state she rules. Now, the very author of I.N.D.I.A. has run away from his own script, with Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar executing yet another breathtaking political somersault to the BJP. Since I.N.D.I.A. was the vehicle that sought to bring the Congress back to centre stage, Nitish's U-turn imparts a twist to that tale too.

The fraught relations between the Congress and the messy ensemble of regional parties had defined the I.N.D.I.A. story from its rosy beginnings to the meltdown it now faces. Till two years ago, non-Congress parties were still trying to float a 'Third Front' equidistant from the UPA as well as the NDA. It was Nitish who coaxed everyone to cede primacy to the Congress. But some partners were always less 'like-minded' than others and jumped on board only because of their desire to dethrone the BJP; individually, many were rivals for the same turf. With the Congress showing new signs of life in the South, and a capacity to attract vote blocs even in the assembly polls it lost in the North, it was natural that its I.N.D.I.A. allies began seeing its potential revival as a threat.



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The big question now is, how does I.N.D.I.A. stack up in the states? One is reminded of the old folk riddle where the tiger, the goat and the bundle of grass can't be on the same boat. In Uttar Pradesh, the Samajwadi Party is offering the Congress only 11 seats out of 80. Theoretically, Bihar now has more seats to go around: the JD(U) and the RJD were earlier taking roughly 17 each of its 40 seats, leaving six for smaller allies. But Nitish's exit is not only a spectacular loss of morale, it fundamentally alters the dynamics. Add the BJP's expected Ram wave to Nitish's captive vote among the Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs), and the women's vote both have been assiduously pursuing. Against that, the RJD will want to maximise all sympathy and counter-polarisation and is unlikely to be too generous to a moribund Congress. As for Jharkhand, it's in a limbo because of CM Hemant Soren's arrest. Mamata, zealously guarding her turf within the state's 42 seats, has kept only a tenuous line open for a restoration of the *entente cordiale* depending on how the jigsaw pieces fall finally. As of now, in all probability, her TMC won't be part of I.N.D.I.A. in Bengal.

It's in the South that the Opposition bloc hopes to surpass the 62 seats out of 130 the UPA had won in the 2019 general election. Its optimism rides on the Congress resurgence in Karnataka and Telangana's state polls. The two chief ministers, Siddaramaiah and A. Revanth Reddy, expect a happy spillover to the parliamentary election. In Karnataka, the BJP had pocketed 25 out of 28 seats in 2019. The Congress, which got only one, feels it's in line to effect a mini reversal in fortunes. In Telangana, similarly, the Congress got only three out of 17 seats in 2019 while the TRS got nine and the BJP four. In the recent assembly polls, it trounced the BRS (the renamed TRS), which makes the Congress very hopeful of carrying over that momentum to the general election. But the BJP, though still a marginal player here, may pool its energies with the BRS to limit that. In Tamil Nadu, led by the ruling DMK, the anti-BJP front is likely to retain pole position: it had won 38 out of 39 seats last time. Kerala's 20 seats, too, will substantially go to I.N.D.I.A., but will host the curious spectacle of a vicious friendly fight between the Left and the Congress.

In Maharashtra, the kaleidoscope is moving in unpredictable ways. Its 48 seats represent the last big I.N.D.I.A. frontier for the BJP. In many ways, it has already been breached. Two of its prime components—the Shiv Sena and the NCP—are already rumps of their original avatars; the renegade groups, helmed by CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Ajit Pawar, both with the BJP. So the original patent-holders, Uddhav Thackeray and Sharad Pawar, are fighting a battle for political survival. An already bubbling political pot is now further roiled by Shinde granting OBC reservations to the Marathas. In the resultant pell-mell, no one really knows which pawn is moving where on the chess board. This anarchic picture-frame is what Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra (BJNY) will enter in March.

In its initial phase, the BJNY caravan has already run into fissured ground in Bengal and Bihar. Perhaps its very entry is a catalyst in that process. Regional chieftains, already under pressure, are wary of sharing any of their hard-won turf with others. No one doubts Rahul's earnestness when he speaks of his *mohabbat ki dukaan*, but the final scorecard in Bihar, for instance, may resemble the tennis score of 40-love as far as his party is concerned. And 'Advantage BJP' defines the situation everywhere.

In this week's cover story, Executive Editor Kaushik Deka chronicles what cynics would call the tale of a death foretold. The full picture of I.N.D.I.A.'s fragmenting political map comes through with inputs from Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava on the nearly unbelievable goings-on in Patna; Special Correspondent Arkamoy Datta Majumdar from Kolkata on the acrimonious collapse of talks with Mamata; Senior Associate Editor Dhaval S. Kulkarni captures Maharashtra's fast-moving frames; and Senior Deputy Editor Amarnath K. Menon examines the various cross-currents in the South. Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan adds a sneak peek at the central BJP's strategy: how it has checkmated I.N.D.I.A. at every step.

The fundamental problem with I.N.D.I.A. is that they have no compelling narrative for the electorate except that they are anti-BJP, Prime Minister Modi in particular. Besides, they have no national leader to project. It seems a Herculean task for the Opposition to pull itself out of the morass it has sunk into and challenge the BJP, especially since the ruling party has the equivalent of Hercules himself.

(Aroon Purie)